

31% foreign now, 38% by 2030?

*Testing PwC Malta's figures for foreign residents
against Eurostat, NSO and Jobsplus data*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

***“...foreign residents now make up 31% of Malta's population”
“...the mix of foreign to local residents potentially
reaching around 38% by 2030.”***

PwC Malta, Summer 2026 Economic Update press release, as posted by Finance Malta, 17 July 2026.
Two fragments, from paragraphs 2 and 6; the 2030 figure comes from PwC's own model.

VERDICT: NOT SUBSTANTIATED

31% right; 38% by 2030 not shown

Version 1.0 · 6 October 2026

Status: right of reply on hold until PwC's report is read

Prepared from public sources and official statistics.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

PwC Malta’s press release on its *Summer 2026 Economic Update* (Finance Malta, 17 July 2026) says: “The latest figures show that foreign residents now make up 31% of Malta’s population”, with “the mix of foreign to local residents potentially reaching around 38% by 2030.”

- 1

The 31% is right. Our calculation from Eurostat data gives 30.9–31.1% non-Maltese citizens at the end of 2025 (if 2025’s change was within the 2010–24 range); the NSO reports 31.1% ♦.
- 2

The definition matters. 32.0% of residents were born abroad already on 1 January 2025, and foreign nationals were 39.8% of registered employment in December 2025 (Jobsplus).
- 3

The 38% is PwC’s own projection. We found no Eurostat or NSO projection by citizenship, and PwC’s report, which sets out its model, could not be read.
- 4

Whether about 38% is reachable turns on naturalisations. On citizenship, 37.5–38.5% of PwC’s 636,000 needs Maltese citizens to fall by at least 1,610 a year in 2026–30. They rose every year 2010–2024; only a projection without future naturalisations, like the Central Bank’s ♦, gives such a fall. The release does not say what PwC assumed.
- 5

Verdict: not substantiated (low confidence). The 31% is right. The 38% has not been shown: PwC states neither its definition nor its naturalisation assumption, and its report could not be read.

THIS CLAIM

SUPPORTED

LARGELY SUPPORTED

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

31% Non-Maltese citizens at end-2025: right (our calculation from Eurostat data: 30.9–31.1%)	32.0% Residents born abroad, 1 January 2025 (Eurostat)	39.8% Foreign nationals in registered employment, December 2025 (Jobsplus)	≥1,610 Fewer Maltese citizens a year in 2026–30 for 37.5–38.5% of 636,000; the count rose every year 2010–2024
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WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP

PwC’s report, or PwC, showing the definition and the naturalisation assumption behind the 38%, reproducible from published inputs: the verdict would move to Largely supported.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN

Evidence that the 38% is counted on a different basis from the 31% (for example country of birth) without saying so; or a correction to the NSO’s end-2025 figure that moved the 31%.

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1 The claim and what we could verify

The words are PwC Malta’s. Finance Malta posted them on 17 July 2026 as an “Industry Update” from PwC, with PwC’s own boilerplate [1]. The Malta Business Weekly reprinted the same text on 19 July [2], and the Malta Chamber (22 July) and Mondaq, under PwC’s name (23 July), carry it too [3]. The release speaks of “our projections” and quotes PwC Malta’s Territory Senior Partner, so we assess it as PwC’s statement. The two figures are in different paragraphs (2 and 6) of the same release.

What PwC says	Where	Access
“...Malta’s population reached 588,254 by year-end 2025. This marks an increase of approximately 14,000 residents (2.4%) from the previous year.”	Para. 1 [1]	Read in full, 6 Oct 2026
“The latest figures show that foreign residents now make up 31% of Malta’s population, with net migration patterns continuing to drive growth.”	Para. 2 [1]	Read in full; no source or definition given
“Based on PwC’s demographic modelling, Malta’s population is projected to reach a base case of 636,000 by 2030.”	Para. 2 [1]	Read in full
“Our projections are based on varying levels of slowdown in current net migration flows. Nonetheless, population is still expected to increase significantly, with the mix of foreign to local residents potentially reaching around 38% by 2030.”	Para. 6 [1] (para. 7 in [2])	Read in full; method in the report
The <i>Summer 2026 Economic Update</i> itself, which “sets out demographic projections”	pwc.com [4]	Not readable: 403 to scripts; no Internet Archive capture
◆ Quoted by two outlets as the report’s words: “... the results suggest that population would still increase significantly, with the mix of foreign to local reaching around 38% in the base case.” Range 624,000–660,000.	Business Now [5], Newsbook [6]	Second-hand

The record’s link. Our intake record pointed to a different Malta Business Weekly article (2 June 2025, by Silvan Mifsud, on a Central Bank of Malta policy note) [21]. That article does not contain the claim: it gives 28.1% of the population as foreign nationals in 2023 and “just over 31%” of the working-age population. The claim’s wording matches the July 2026 release, which we rate here.

SCOPE NOTE

This check tests two statistics and how they were produced. It does not assess migration policy, the economic effects of population growth, or the hospital-bed and electricity figures in the same release. The words “foreign” and “local” are PwC’s; we use the statistical terms (non-Maltese citizens, born abroad) when we test them.

2 Method

Questions. (1) Were foreign residents 31% of Malta’s population at the time of the release, and on what definition? (2) Does “around 38% by 2030” come from a published projection, and can it be shown from published figures?

Evidence. We downloaded from Eurostat’s dissemination API on 6 October 2026, with Eurostat’s flags: the population on 1 January by citizenship and by country of birth [10, 11], the demographic balance [12], Census 2021 [13], immigration, emigration and acquisitions of citizenship by citizenship [14], births by the mother’s citizenship and deaths by citizenship [15], and the EUROPOP2025 projections [16]. We downloaded Jobsplus’s workbooks on foreign nationals in employment and total employment [18, 19]. The NSO’s release of 9 July 2026 [7] and PwC’s report [4] refused automated access; their figures are used only as reported by news outlets, marked ◆. The Central Bank of Malta’s policy note was read as its abstract (Crossref) [20]. Every figure is recomputed by `tools/cc-099-report/calc.py` from `data/cc-099/`. A Crossref search (three queries, logged in

literature/CC-099/notes.md) found no peer-reviewed study of Malta's foreign-population share or its projection.

Definitions. Eurostat counts usual residents (a stay of at least 12 months, or intended to last that long); citizenship is the legal bond with a state, and a non-national is a citizen of another country or stateless [17]. The population on 1 January of a year is the population at the end of the year before: Eurostat's 1 January 2026 total is 588,254, the figure PwC gives for the end of 2025 [1, 12]. We read “around 38%” as 37.5–38.5%, the values that round to 38, and apply the same tolerance to every reading.

Grades. Official statistics and administrative data are grade C under our scale. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What “foreign residents” can mean

The release does not define “foreign residents”. Three published measures fit the phrase, and they differ by several points (Figure 1, Table 1). Counted by **citizenship**, a person born in Malta to foreign parents is foreign, and a foreigner who becomes a Maltese citizen is not. Counted by **country of birth**, Maltese citizens born abroad are included. Jobsplus reports **foreign nationals in registered employment**, a share of employment, not of residents.

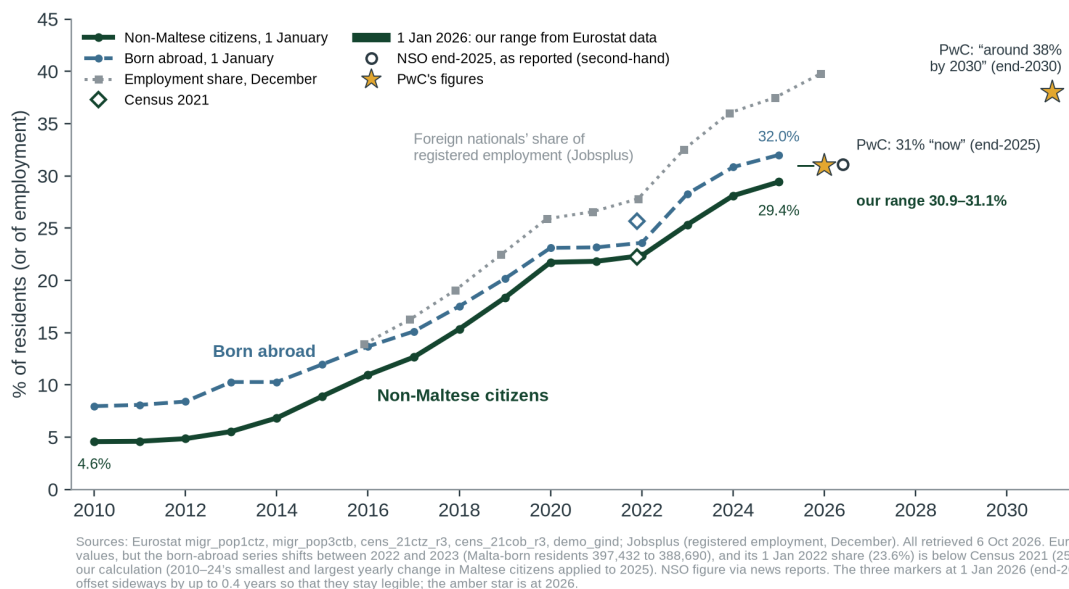


Figure 1. Share of Malta's residents who are non-Maltese citizens and who were born abroad (Eurostat, 1 January), and foreign nationals' share of registered employment (Jobsplus, December). Census 2021 (reference date 21 November 2021 [22]) is shown as diamonds. The green bar at 1 January 2026 is our calculation from Eurostat data (section 4); the hollow circle is the NSO's end-2025 figure as reported ◆. PwC's 31% is plotted at the end of 2025 and its 38% at the end of 2030; PwC published no path between them.

Measure	Value	Date	Source	Grade
Non-Maltese citizens (other EU 8.0%, non-EU 21.4%)	29.4% (168,938)	1 Jan 2025	Eurostat [10]	C
Non-Maltese citizens: our calculation from Eurostat data, if 2025's change was within the 2010–24 range	30.9–31.1%	1 Jan 2026	calculated [10, 12]	C
◆ Non-Maltese citizens, NSO	31.1% (182,693)	end-2025	NSO via news [8, 9]	C
Born abroad	32.0% (183,765)	1 Jan 2025	Eurostat [11]	C
Census: non-Maltese citizens / born abroad	22.2% / 25.7%	21 Nov 2021	Eurostat [13]	C
Foreign nationals in registered employment (full- and part-time)	39.8% (135,417)	Dec 2025	Jobsplus [18, 19]	C
Foreign nationals in full-time registered employment	42.2%	Dec 2025	Jobsplus [18, 19]	C

Table 1. All values in data/cc-099/checks.csv. Eurostat’s 2010–2025 citizenship and birth series carry no flags (earlier years carry a break in 2001 and 2009 and an estimate in 2006). Unflagged, the born-abroad series shifts between 2022 and 2023 (Malta-born 397,432 to 388,690), and its 1 January 2022 share (23.6%) is below Census 2021 (25.7%); we use only its 2025 level. Employment shares are not comparable with shares of residents.

4 Testing the 31%

The latest year for which Eurostat publishes Malta’s population by citizenship is 1 January 2025: 29.4% non-Maltese citizens, up from 28.1% a year earlier and 4.6% in 2010 [10]. PwC’s “latest figures” refer to the end of 2025, a year later. Eurostat already gives that total, 588,254 on 1 January 2026, matching PwC’s figure and its 14,004 rise (2.44%) in 2025 [12].

Eurostat has not yet published the 2026 split, so we bound it ourselves. The number of Maltese citizens rose in every year from 2010 to 2024, by between 237 (2024) and 1,394 (2011) a year [10]. If 2025’s change lay within that range, Maltese citizens numbered 405,549–406,706 on 1 January 2026, and non-Maltese citizens were **30.9–31.1%** of 588,254 (our calculation). Both ends round to 31%.

The NSO’s own figure agrees. Its World Population Day release (NR 120/2026, 9 July 2026) is not readable from our network, but four outlets report it: 68.9% Maltese citizens and 31.1% non-Maltese citizens at the end of 2025, or 182,693 people [8, 9] ◆. That implies 405,561 Maltese citizens, 249 more than a year earlier, inside our range. PwC does not name its source; the 31% matches the NSO’s citizenship figure, rounded (our identification). By country of birth the share would be higher: 32.0% were born abroad a year earlier [11].

5 Testing the 38% by 2030

Is it an official projection?

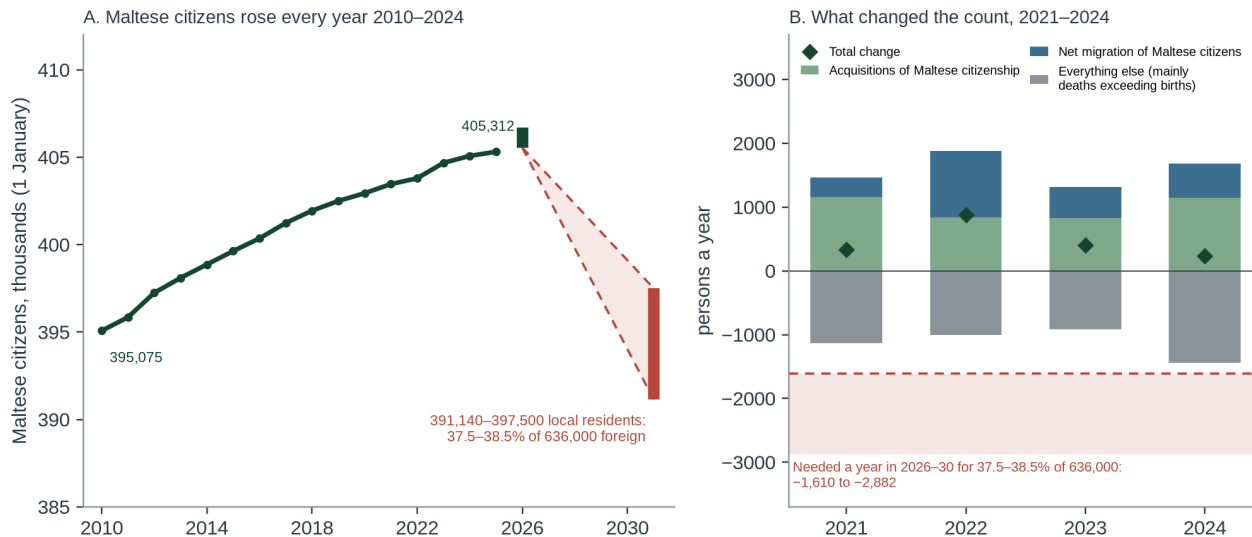
No. Eurostat's EUROPOP2025 projections (June 2026) give Malta's population by age and sex only, with no split by citizenship or country of birth [16]. The Central Bank of Malta wrote in 2025 that it projected the native Maltese population itself "in the absence of demographic projections specifically covering the native Maltese population" [20]. The NSO's website refuses automated access, and a web search found no NSO projection by citizenship; Newsbook reports that a parliamentary reply confirmed the government holds no formal population projections for the next four years ♦ [6]. The 38% is PwC's own model result: the release attributes it to "our projections", based on "varying levels of slowdown in current net migration flows" [1].

What "38%" means

"The mix of foreign to local residents" could be read as a ratio of foreign to local. On 1 January 2025 there were already 41.7 non-Maltese citizens for every 100 Maltese citizens [10], so a ratio of 38 would be a fall, which the release does not describe. We read the 38% as a share of all residents, as the 31% is.

What it requires

At PwC's base case of 636,000 residents, "around 38%" (37.5–38.5%) leaves 391,140–397,500 local residents. On the citizenship basis of the 31%, local residents are Maltese citizens, 405,549–406,706 at the end of 2025 by our calculation (section 4). Reaching 397,500 by the end of 2030 needs a fall of at least **1,610 a year** over 2026–2030; exactly 38% needs 2,246–2,477 a year, and 38.5% up to 3,113. (Counted from 1 January 2025, the figures would be 1,302–2,362 a year, but that spreads the fall over 2025, when the count rose.) Figure 2 sets this against what has happened.



Sources: Eurostat migr_pop1ctz, migr_imm1ctz, migr_em1ctz, migr_acq (retrieved 6 Oct 2026); PwC base case of 636,000 and "around 38%" (press release, 17 Jul 2026), taken as 37.5–38.5%. The shaded paths in A run from the lower end of our 1 Jan 2026 range (405,549) to the end of 2030. "Everything else" is the remainder after migration and acquisitions; births to Maltese mothers minus deaths of Maltese citizens (Eurostat demo_faczc, demo_maczc) were -857 to -1,119 a year.

Figure 2. A: Maltese citizens on 1 January, 2010–2025, our 1 January 2026 range, and the number left for local residents by 37.5–38.5% of 636,000. B: the parts of each year's change, 2021–2024: acquisitions of Maltese citizenship, net migration of Maltese citizens, and the remainder, against the yearly fall needed in 2026–2030 [10, 14, 15].

Year	Total change	Net migration of Maltese	Acquisitions of citizenship	Remainder	Births to Maltese mothers minus deaths of Maltese
2021	+331	+306	+1,156	−1,131	−900
2022	+881	+1,039	+842	−1,000	−921
2023	+400	+489	+825	−914	−857
2024	+237	+533	+1,145	−1,441	−1,119
Needed a year, 2026–30, for 37.5–38.5% of 636,000	−1,610 to −2,882	from 405,549 (−1,841 to −3,113 from 406,706)			

Table 2. Maltese citizens, components of change (persons). Remainder = total change minus net migration and acquisitions; it also includes losses of citizenship and statistical adjustment. Births are counted by the mother’s citizenship, which can differ from the child’s (general context), so the last column is approximate. Eurostat [10, 14, 15]; acquisitions for 2010 carry a break flag (not used).

Even if no foreigner became a Maltese citizen and no Maltese citizen moved in or out, the remainder fell by 914–1,441 a year in 2021–2024, a slower fall than the 1,610 needed. For comparison only, not as forecasts: if 2024’s remainder (−1,441), the largest, repeated every year from our end-2025 range, the non-Maltese share at 636,000 would be 37.2–37.4% (37.6% if 2025 is included), at the edge of “around 38%”; had the count stayed at its 1 January 2025 level, it would be 36.3%. The release gives no local-population path. In Business Now’s paraphrase of the report, the local population “has remained at just over 400,000” ♦ [5].

Other readings come close to 38%. A projection without future naturalisations, like the Central Bank’s ♦, gives about 38% (section 6). On **country of birth**, 390,485 residents were born in Malta on 1 January 2025 [11]; at that count, 38.6% of 636,000 would be born abroad, just above the band, and 37.5–38.5% would need 655–7,015 more Malta-born residents by 2030. At the top of PwC’s reported range, 660,000 ♦ [5, 6], the 1 January 2025 count of Maltese citizens would leave 38.6% non-Maltese. The release states none of these.

Context: total population

PwC’s base case sits between Eurostat’s projections. EUROPOP2025 gives 621,470 on 1 January 2030 and 628,876 on 1 January 2031 in its baseline, and 650,230 and 663,463 with higher migration [16]. Its baseline for 1 January 2026 (585,012) was already 3,242 below the outcome [12, 16]. We do not rate the 636,000; it is the denominator PwC chose.

6 Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Could the local population fall fast enough for about 38%?

ONLY IF NATURALISATIONS ARE LEFT OUT

EVIDENCE THAT THE LOCAL POPULATION COULD FALL

The Central Bank of Malta projects “a persistent decline and ageing of the native Maltese population” [20]. Its baseline, as reported ♦, falls from 405,075 (2023) to about 350,000 [21] or 347,000 [23] by 2050: about 2,040–2,230 a year on average, faster than the 1,610 needed. Its start equals Eurostat’s Maltese citizens on 1 January 2024 [10], the basis of the 31%, but it leaves out people who acquire citizenship ♦ [23]. Applied to 2026–2030 that average gives 37.8–38.0% at 636,000. Its path to 2030 is not known to us, so this decides nothing.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

The number of Maltese citizens rose in every year 2010–2024 [10]. In 2021–2024, 825–1,156 people a year became Maltese citizens and net migration of Maltese citizens was positive [14]. Even with both set to zero, the remainder fell by at most 1,441 a year, short of the 1,610 needed (Table 2). Births to Maltese mothers were below deaths of Maltese citizens by only 857–1,119 a year [15].

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the answer turns on naturalisations. With them, as recorded, the count rises; without them, a CBM-style projection gives about 38%. The release does not say which PwC assumed, and only its report could show it.

Q2 Is the 38% on the same definition as the 31%?

UNKNOWN

EVIDENCE OF THE CITIZENSHIP BASIS

The release uses one phrase for both (“foreign residents”; “the mix of foreign to local residents”) and gives no change of definition. The 31% matches the NSO’s citizenship figure (section 4). In Business Now’s paraphrase, the report puts the local population “at just over 400,000” ♦ [5], which fits Maltese citizens (405,312 on 1 January 2025) rather than Malta-born residents (390,485) [10, 11].

EVIDENCE OF A BIRTHPLACE BASIS

On country of birth, 38.6% would be born abroad at 636,000 with the 1 January 2025 count of Malta-born residents [11]. Business Now’s “In 2019, it was 20 per cent” ♦ [5] matches the born-abroad share on 1 January 2019 (20.2%), not citizenship (18.4%) [10, 11]; and 31% also matches born abroad on 1 January 2024 (30.8%).

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the clues point both ways and are second-hand. Either the 38% is on the citizenship basis and needs a fall in Maltese citizens that only a no-naturalisation projection gives, or it is on another basis and cannot be set beside the 31%. Either way the figure has not been shown.

7

Testing the claim

The verdict rests on A and B, the two figures in the claim. C is the release’s own context and is rated for completeness.

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. “foreign residents now make up 31% of Malta’s population”	Our calculation from Eurostat data: 30.9–31.1% non-Maltese citizens on 1 January 2026 (if 2025’s change was within the 2010–24 range); 29.4% a year earlier [10, 12]. The NSO’s 31.1% agrees ♦ [8]. By country of birth the share is higher (32.0% in 2025) [11].	ACCURATE
B. “the mix of foreign to local residents potentially reaching around 38% by 2030”	PwC’s own model; no Eurostat or NSO projection by citizenship found [16, 20]. On citizenship, 37.5–38.5% of 636,000 needs Maltese citizens to fall by at least 1,610 a year in 2026–30; recorded data show a rise every year 2010–2024 [10, 14]. Only a projection without future naturalisations, like the CBM’s ♦, gives such a fall. PwC states neither its definition nor this assumption; report not readable [4].	NOT SUBSTANTIATED
C. “...Malta’s population reached 588,254 by year-end 2025 ... approximately 14,000 residents (2.4%)” (context)	Eurostat: 588,254 on 1 January 2026; +14,004 (2.44%) in 2025 [12].	ACCURATE

8

Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

The 31% is right. The 38% by 2030 has not been shown: PwC does not state its definition of foreign and local residents or its assumption about naturalisations, and its report could not be read. Confidence: low.

Why. (1) The current figure reproduces from our calculation on Eurostat data and agrees with the NSO’s ♦. (2) The 2030 figure is PwC’s own model result, not an official projection, and the release gives one sentence on how it was made. (3) On citizenship, “around 38%” of PwC’s 636,000 needs Maltese citizens to fall by at least 1,610 a year over 2026–2030 (about 2,250 for exactly 38%). Recorded data show them rising every year 2010–2024, because naturalisations and returning citizens outweigh the natural decrease; only a projection that leaves out future naturalisations, as the Central Bank’s does ♦, gives a fall of that size. On country of birth the figure is closer, but the

31% matches citizenship. (4) The release states neither its definition nor its naturalisation assumption, so the figure cannot be checked from what PwC published. (5) Confidence is low: the evidence on the 38% points both ways, the deciding document (PwC's report) could not be read, and the NSO's end-2025 figure is second-hand.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say that the share of foreign residents will not rise, that PwC's population total is wrong, or anything about migration policy. It addresses only whether the two figures are supported by the evidence offered and available.

Right of reply. A reply from PwC Malta is on hold until its *Summer 2026 Economic Update* is read, because the explanation of the 38% may be in it. If the report shows the method, the verdict will be revisited before any reply is sought.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The definition of "foreign" and "local" behind the 38%: citizenship, as in the 31%, or country of birth.
- ☐ The base-case number of local residents for 2030, and whether the model counts future naturalisations, with its assumptions for births, deaths and migration.
- ☐ The share of foreign residents at the low (624,000) and high (660,000) ends of PwC's range (range known second-hand ♦).
- ☐ From the NSO: the end-2025 population by citizenship as a published table (Eurostat's 1 January 2026 split was not yet available on 6 October 2026).

9

Limitations

- PwC's report could not be read (pwc.com refuses automated access and the Internet Archive has no copy); it may explain the 38%.
- The NSO's end-2025 figures are second-hand (nso.gov.mt refuses automated access; an Internet Archive copy exists but could not be opened from our network). Four outlets agree.
- The 30.9–31.1% for 1 January 2026 is our calculation from Eurostat data, valid if 2025's change in Maltese citizens lay within the 2010–24 range; Eurostat has not yet published the 2026 split.
- The Central Bank of Malta's note was read as its abstract; its baseline figures are second-hand (♦), and its path to 2030 is unknown.
- Births are recorded by the mother's citizenship, so the last column of Table 2 is approximate.
- Jobsplus's own label is "Foreign Nationals Employed in Malta & Gozo"; "registered employment" is our short name for the series. It counts employment, not residents, so it is not comparable with population shares.
- Figures quoted from the report by Business Now and Newsbook are second-hand (♦) and decide no rating.

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Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	6 Oct 2026	First issue. Right of reply to PwC Malta on hold until its Summer 2026 Economic Update is read.